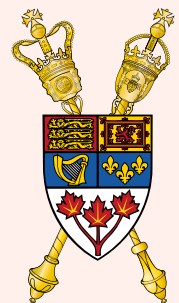


Parliamentary Simulations

Committee Meeting

 Teacher Guide



PARLIAMENT | PARLEMENT
CANADA

Table of contents



At a glance	3
1 Getting ready	5
I. Assign student roles	5
II. Prepare supporting materials	7
III. Optional: Select an example of a committee meeting to show the class	7
2 Introductory class: Learning about committees	8
I. Minds on - 5 minutes	8
II. Direct instruction: Committees – 25 minutes	9
III. Learning about the bill – 15 minutes	9
IV. Role assignment – 5 minutes	10
3 Groupwork class: Preparing for the simulation	11
I. Minds on – 10 minutes	11
II. Breakout group 1: Arguments for and against the bill – 10 minutes	12
III. Breakout group 2: Goals and strategies – 30 minutes	12
4 Simulation class: Running the simulation	13
I. Classroom setup	13
II. Suggested timing	14
5 Consolidating learning	14



At a glance



In this simulation, students play the roles of senators, a Cabinet minister and witnesses at a Senate committee meeting about the *Vegetable Harmony Act* – a fictitious bill that would limit the rights of parents to serve unpopular vegetables to their children. Students examine the proposed bill, discuss the issue, consider changes and hold a vote.



Recommended grade levels

Grades 9-12
QC Secondary III-CEGEP



Time required

Three 50-minute
class periods, plus
preparation time



Skills

- Critical thinking
- Research and analysis
- Perspective taking
- Collaboration

Learning outcomes

Students will:

- ✓ Gain a deeper understanding of the legislative process
- ✓ Better understand how parliamentarians and members of the public contribute to committee work
- ✓ Gain an appreciation for the importance of Senate committees in parliamentary democracy
- ✓ Develop their public speaking and analysis skills

Steps

1 Getting ready

Preparing the materials for the simulation

2 Introductory class

Learning about committees and the legislative process

3 Groupwork class

Groupwork to prepare for the simulation

4 Simulation class

Running the simulation

5 Consolidating learning

Reflecting on the simulation and lessons learned



Simulation Instructions



Getting ready



- I. Assign student roles
- II. Prepare supporting materials
- III. Optional: Select example speeches

🕒 15 min

🕒 30 min

🕒 30 min

I. Assign student roles

🕒 15 min

During the simulation, students will play the roles of the committee chair, other senators, a Cabinet minister and committee witnesses. This package includes distinct roles for up to 30 students.

As the teacher, you will play the committee clerk. You will help the chair by keeping time for each section, keeping the list of speakers, recording votes and assisting with amendments.

Choose roles

Select students to fill each of the following roles and record their assignments in the table below, as well as in the Character Profiles section of the **student package**:

🟦 Committee chair (1)

This student has the challenging role of running the meeting and maintaining order.

🟢 Cabinet minister (1)

This student must confidently understand the bill from many angles, present it to committee and answer questions about it.

🔴 Senators (up to 19)

These students ask questions to witnesses, debate clauses and vote on the bill. Four senators also introduce amendments to the bill towards the end of the simulation.

🟠 Witnesses (up to 9)

These students present specific points of view on the bill and answer questions.



Role group	Title	Student
Cabinet minister	Minister of Food	
Senators - Affiliation A	Mr./Madam/Mx. Chair	
	Senator <i>Presents an amendment</i>	
	Senator	
	Senator	
	Senator	
Senators - Affiliation B	Senator <i>Presents an amendment</i>	
	Senator	
	Senator	
	Senator	
	Senator	
Senators - Affiliation C	Senator <i>Presents an amendment</i>	
	Senator	
	Senator	
	Senator	
	Senator	
Senators - Affiliation D	Senator <i>Presents an amendment</i>	
	Senator	
	Senator	
	Senator	
	Senator	
Witnesses – Canadian Vegetable Growers Association	Mr./Ms./Mx.	
	Mr./Ms./Mx.	
	Mr./Ms./Mx.	
Witnesses – Council for the Rights of Families	Mr./Ms./Mx.	
	Mr./Ms./Mx.	
	Mr./Ms./Mx.	
Witnesses – Restaurant Association of Canada	Mr./Ms./Mx.	
	Mr./Ms./Mx.	
	Mr./Ms./Mx.	

II. Prepare supporting materials

🕒 30 min

Prepare copies of:

Vegetable Harmony Act

This is the mock bill students will examine during the simulation. It has been designed to replicate the formatting and language of an actual bill.

Student package

This package includes character profiles, an overview of each role, the rules and decorum for a committee meeting and worksheets to prepare for the simulation.

Simulation procedure quick sheet

This quick sheet contains the detailed steps for running the simulation. Every student should have access to it for reference.

Exit slip

This worksheet includes reflection questions to help your students consolidate learning.

Name cards

Provide students with white paper and markers so that they can create name cards to display their titles and role group during the simulation.

III. Optional: Select an example of a committee meeting to show the class

🕒 30 min

You may wish to play a few clips from Senate committee meetings during the introductory class and discuss them with your students. Consider selecting committee recordings related to your class's interests or topical issues. If you choose to show recordings to your class, select clips that show:

- a** A Cabinet minister addressing a committee;
- b** Witnesses presenting information and responding to senators' questions; and/or
- c** Senators voting on amendments to a bill.

To select recordings, go to the CPAC homepage and search for "Senate committee" or use the following link: <https://www.cpac.ca/program?id=23>.



Introductory class: Learning about committees



Before running the simulation, students will spend two 50-minute class periods preparing. The first class period is dedicated to introducing the work of committees and familiarizing students with their roles.

The **intro class slide deck**, available on the Committee simulation web page, will familiarize your students with committee work by introducing key concepts they will need to know during the simulation.

I. Minds on	⌚ 05 min
II. Direct instruction: Committees	⌚ 25 min
III. Learning about the bill	⌚ 15 min
IV. Role assignment	⌚ 05 min

I. Minds on

⌚ 05 min

Display the prompt in the **intro class slide deck**:

? **“If you were responsible for making a new law, what steps would you take to make sure it is fair for all Canadians?”**

Spend five minutes discussing the prompt with your class. After students have shared their thoughts, explain that committees study bills in detail with support from witnesses who express their points of view on bills. They analyze and vote on each clause, ensuring that all parts of the bill are examined closely. Since Parliament studies many bills at the same time, committees allow parliamentarians to divide this work and focus on particular public policy areas. This work is part of the process of a bill becoming a law.



II. Direct instruction: Committees

🕒 25 min

Using the **intro class slide deck**, explain how parliamentary committees work and who is involved.

Optional: If you selected video clips of committee meetings, show them to your class. As a class, analyze what you saw. Discussion questions may include:

- ? Did you think the Cabinet minister was persuasive when they presented the bill? Why or why not?
- ? What kinds of questions did senators ask the Cabinet minister? How were they different from the questions they asked the witnesses?
- ? How did the witnesses speak about the bill?
- ? Would you have voted to pass the amendment based on what you saw? Why or why not?

Next, review the **simulation procedure quick sheet**, linking it back to what your class observed in the recordings (if applicable).

III. Learning about the bill

🕒 15 min

Distribute copies of the ***Vegetable Harmony Act*** and use it to explain the sections of a bill and the types of clauses included. Next, analyze the ***Vegetable Harmony Act*** as a class.

Tip: Not every section needs to be examined in detail. The most crucial sections for the simulation are outlined below. Discuss the questions in the table below.

Title page	? Based on the title only, what do you think the purpose of the bill might be?
-------------------	--

Preamble	? What reasons are given for introducing this bill?
-----------------	---

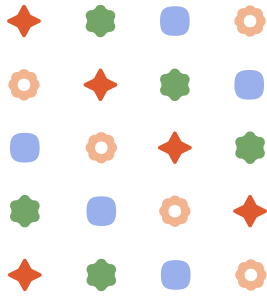
Clauses 4-6	? Clause 4 sets out the conditions under which parents can serve vegetables to their children. What are they? What is the role of the advisory committee in Clause 6?
--------------------	--

Clauses 7-10	? Clauses 7-10 outline the penalties for violating the rules of the bill. What are they?
---------------------	--



IV. Role assignments

🕒 05 min



Inform the students of their roles. Distribute the appropriate sections of the **student package** as well as copies of the ***Vegetable Harmony Act***, available on the Committee simulation web page. Direct students to read their assigned character profile, role overview and background information.

Respond to any clarifying questions about students' roles.



Groupwork class: Preparing for the simulation



Students will spend one 50-minute class working together to prepare for the simulation.

I. Minds on

🕒 10 min

II. Breakout group 1: Arguments for and against the bill

🕒 10 min

III. Breakout group 2: Goals and strategies

🕒 30 min

I. Minds on

🕒 10 min

Invite students to read the ***Vegetable Harmony Act*** a second time, indicating how their character would respond to each clause of the bill by writing the following symbols on their copy of the bill:



Support



Oppose



Interesting /
notable



Unclear / want more
information

II. Breakout group 1: Arguments for and against the bill

🕒 10 min

Divide students into random groups of 3-4 students. The goal of this breakout group is for students to gain a broad understanding of arguments for and against the bill from multiple perspectives.

Have your students spend 10 minutes discussing the ***Vegetable Harmony Act***, coming up with as many arguments for and against the bill as they can think of. They should make notes on their group's arguments using the t-chart in the **student package**.



III. Breakout group 2: Goals and strategies

🕒 30 min

Next, divide your students into the following groups based on their roles:

✦ Senators, Affiliation A	✦ Senators, Affiliation B
✦ Senators, Affiliation C	✦ Senators, Affiliation D
⚙️ Witnesses	🗣️ Committee chair *
🌿 Cabinet minister *	

Using the table provided in the **student package**, senators and witnesses should identify their goals for the committee meeting and strategies to achieve them. Circulate during the activity, encouraging students to develop questions and arguments based on their character's position on the bill.

** The committee chair and the Cabinet minister should float between all groups as silent observers. This allows both roles to have a broad overview of each group's goals and strategies going into the committee.*



Simulation class: Running the simulation



During the simulation, senators will hear presentations about the proposed bill from a Cabinet minister and witnesses. They will then examine the bill clause-by-clause before suggesting amendments and voting on whether to report it to the Senate.

- I. Classroom setup
- II. Suggested timing

I. Classroom setup

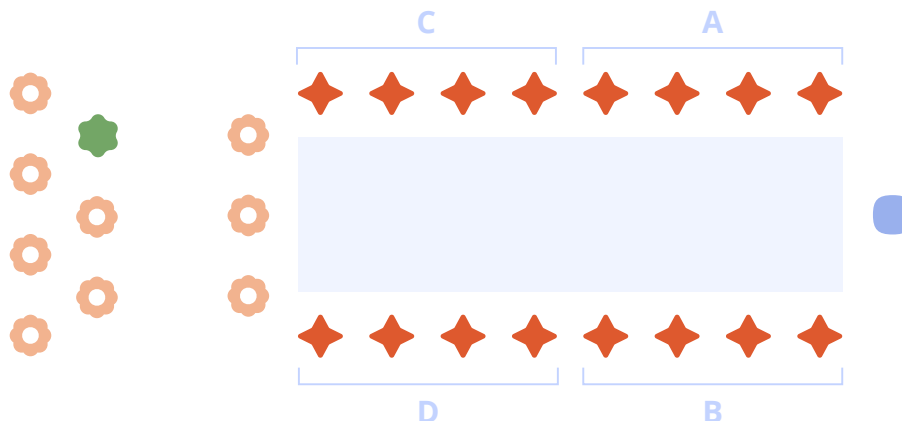
The following classroom setup is recommended to optimize the flow of the simulation. Other arrangements may work better in some classrooms.

Configure the classroom tables into a rectangle. The chair and Clerk should sit at the head of the rectangle. Place two seats for witnesses who are currently addressing the committee at the opposite end of the rectangle.

Seat senators with their Senate affiliation groups, with A and B closest to the chair and Clerk. Ensure Affiliation A is on the right and Affiliation B is on the left. Affiliations C and D can sit in the remaining chairs, with group members seated together.

Create a gallery of additional seating behind the witnesses for the Cabinet minister and witnesses who are waiting for their turn to speak.

Using white paper and markers, ask students to make a name card, with “Senator [Last Name]” on it.



II. Suggested timing

The simulation will run according to the **simulation procedure quick sheet** and in accordance with the rules and decorum outlined in the **student package**. As the Clerk, you will assist the chair in keeping time for each section of the simulation, keeping the list of speakers, recording votes and assisting with amendments.

Suggested timing for a 50-minute simulation is as follows:

- Introductions by the chair – 2 minutes
- Presentation by the Minister of Food, followed by questions and answers from senators – 5 minutes
- Presentations by the three pairs of witnesses, each one followed by questions and answers from senators – 20 minutes
- Clause-by-clause examination of the bill and amendments – 20 minutes
- Vote on whether to report the bill back to the Senate - 3 minutes
- Adjournment (official end of the simulation)

Consolidating learning

Reflection on the simulation

🕒 10 min

An **exit slip** is provided on the Committee simulation web page to help your students reflect on the simulation. The exit slip will help students:

- Articulate what they learned about parliamentary committees;
- Indicate what they want to learn more about or need further clarification on; and
- Reflect on the differences between the committee simulation and a real-life parliamentary committee.

